



Bob Sternfels

Global Managing Partner

1926

Founded

~40,000

People

~25,000

AI agents

~40%

Work that is AI

~\$16B

Revenue (2023)

01 Who You're Meeting

Bob Sternfels — Global Managing Partner, McKinsey & Company.

In role: Elected March 2021 for a term from 1 July 2021; re-elected in 2024 for a second and final three-year term

Today: Chairs the Shareholders Council, McKinsey's elected board, and is driving the firm's restructuring around AI agents — with human headcount down more than 10% and a stated goal of pairing every employee with one or more agents.

The most directly relevant background in this contact list to an infrastructure private-equity firm: **he led McKinsey's Private Equity & Principal Investors practice globally**, alongside its Operations practice in the Americas. He joined McKinsey in San Francisco in 1994, spent six years in Johannesburg, and has worked with colleagues in nearly every office. Before becoming global managing partner he led the firm's client capabilities globally, expanding its digital, advanced analytics, implementation, transformation and sustainability capabilities and launching the Sustainability Practice in April 2021.

Career: Global Managing Partner, McKinsey & Company; Leader of client capabilities globally, McKinsey & Company; Global leader, Private Equity & Principal Investors Practice, McKinsey & Company; Leader, Operations Practice in the Americas, McKinsey & Company

Education: University of Oxford (Rhodes Scholar); Stanford University

The company: The most prestigious strategy firm, and the one making the most aggressive claims about restructuring itself around AI. QuantumBlack, a 1,700-person unit, now drives initiatives accounting for roughly 40% of the firm's work — while headcount has fallen more than 10% and about 10% of non-client-facing staff are being cut over 18 to 24 months.

What they sell: Strategy, operations, organisation and technology consulting, with QuantumBlack as the AI and advanced analytics arm and Lilli as the proprietary internal AI tool.

02 Where The Company Sits

McKinsey is doing publicly what most of this peer set is doing quietly: shrinking the support base, holding or growing the client-facing pyramid, and filling the gap with agents. Sternfels' stated goal is every employee paired with one or more agents, and he has said he expects agent count to match human headcount.

03 Talking Points

- He ran the PE practice globally. Of every consulting leader tracked here, he needs the least explanation of how a fund thinks.
- He is serving a second and final term ending mid-2027, so a successor process will run during any multi-year engagement.
- His AI agent claims are firm-reported and the counts vary between tellings. He is the right person to ask what is actually measured.

What to pressure-test about the company:

- No revenue disclosure at all — nothing in the AI narrative can be tested against financial performance
- Headcount fell more than 10% in eighteen months, and a further ~10% cut to non-client-facing staff is under way
- Revenue growth reportedly flatlined before the restructuring, which is the context the AI story sits inside

04 GIP Context

GIP: No publicly disclosed GIP relationship. McKinsey works extensively with private equity and infrastructure owners, so an existing relationship at deal or fund level is plausible and would not be public. Check internally before assuming a clean slate.

BlackRock: None publicly disclosed.

Others at McKinsey & Company: Alex Singla (Senior Partner, Co-Lead of QuantumBlack)

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